> Should an arrangement at any future time be concluded for the passage of troops through Egypt, the importance of the Great Indian Peninsula Railway would be vastly increased.
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> The great trunk line, running by the Malseje Ghaut in the direction of Nagpoor, would be the most direct which could possibly be selected to connect Bombay and Calcutta.

Such reports were slowly tilting the scales in favour of the railways. The debate finally ended with a 'push' from Governor General James Andrew Broun-Ramsay, First Marquess of Dalhousie, or simply Lord Dalhousie. (He was the Governor General of India between 12 January 1848 and 28 February 1856.) A fan of the railways, he drew up a map and wrote minutes on how improving internal communication in India was important and how the railways would play a key role in it. The minutes are today a central document of Indian Railways' history. A key directive for construction was to refrain from embellishments for station infrastructure. Unlike stations in England, there was to be no extravaganza, only simple stations and railway tracks. Thus, the process of introducing the railways into the subcontinent began. India was now at a crucial juncture, where its primary mode of transport—carts and carriages drawn by oxen or horses—was set to change for good. The age of the railways was about to dawn.

Howrah and Bombay, on the eastern and the western coasts respectively, were in the race to get the first railway line. It was the talking point locally, and one of the most discussed topics in periodicals and at public gatherings, with merchants and traders from both these places trying to take the lead, forming associations, gaining backing and building public support to further their cause. Surveys and studies were conducted. Among the public, there was curiosity, questions, calculations and, of course, superstitions. 'What if…?' was the common beginning for the most frequently asked questions. The key question was the same as was discussed earlier—whether it would be profitable to those who were investing in it heavily. The masses, of course, considered it evil, as they couldn't imagine how a fire-spitting metal could have a life of its own and run a few hundred kilometres.

However, once the idea was formalized, the processes of formation moved speedily. The Bill to incorporate the GIPR on the western coast came up before the Parliament in England in March 1847. It was initially withdrawn after opposition from the East India Company over certain clauses, but was re-tabled two years later, on 1 August 1849, and was cleared. Soon, a formal contract was signed on 17 August 1849 between the